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ONLY TWO PLAYERS FROM THE 2011 ASIAN CUP SQUAD – SUNIL CHHETRI AND GURPREET SINGH SANDHU – ARE PART OF THE 2024 EDITION, AND THEIR LEADERSHIP WILL PLAY A CRUCIAL ROLE IN INSPIRING THE TEAM

“We’re going to do everything, but there is no time for us to work (enough) in the 12–13 days. It’s nothing to prepare for the teams we’re going to face.”

Injury concerns

While India has experimented with formations throughout 2023, its most consistent shape has been 4-2-3-1, with a congested mid-block in front of a four-man backline to thwart counterattacks.

In defence, Anwar’s absence will

Tough ask: Indian team head coach Igor Stimac has said he will be able to provide results if he gets the adequate amount of time to prepare with the players. AIFF MEDIA

be the biggest hole. The Mohun Bagan Super Giant defender was not only a left-footed centre-back but also a ball-playing one, creating pin-point long balls for counterattacks. Though Mumbai City FC captain Rahul Bheke is expected to partner Sandesh Jhingan, two defensive-minded centre-backs will not offer balance in Stimac’s preferred shape.

“Injuries don’t help. When you lose a couple of main players, never mind their age or experience, it is much more difficult because there is a reason why he is there in the starting eleven,” Stimac said.

While Stimac has gone with the trio of Ashique, Sahal Abdul Samad, and Lallianzuala Chhangte — in



INDIA SQUAD FOR THE AFC ASIAN CUP QATAR 2023

Goalkeepers: Amrinder Singh, Gurpreet Singh Sandhu, Vishal Kaith.

Defenders: Akash Mishra, Lalchungnunga, Mehtab Singh, Nikhil Poojary, Pritam Kotal, Rahul Bheke, Sandesh Jhingan, Subhasish Bose.

Midfielders: Anirudh Thapa, Brandon Fernandes, Deepak Tangri, Lalengmawia Ralte, Liston Colaco, Naorem Mahesh Singh, Sahal Abdul Samad, Suresh Singh Wangjam, Udanta Singh.

Forwards: Ishan Pandita, Lallianzuala Chhangte, Manvir Singh, Rahul Kannoly Praveen, Sunil Chhetri, Vikram Partap Singh.